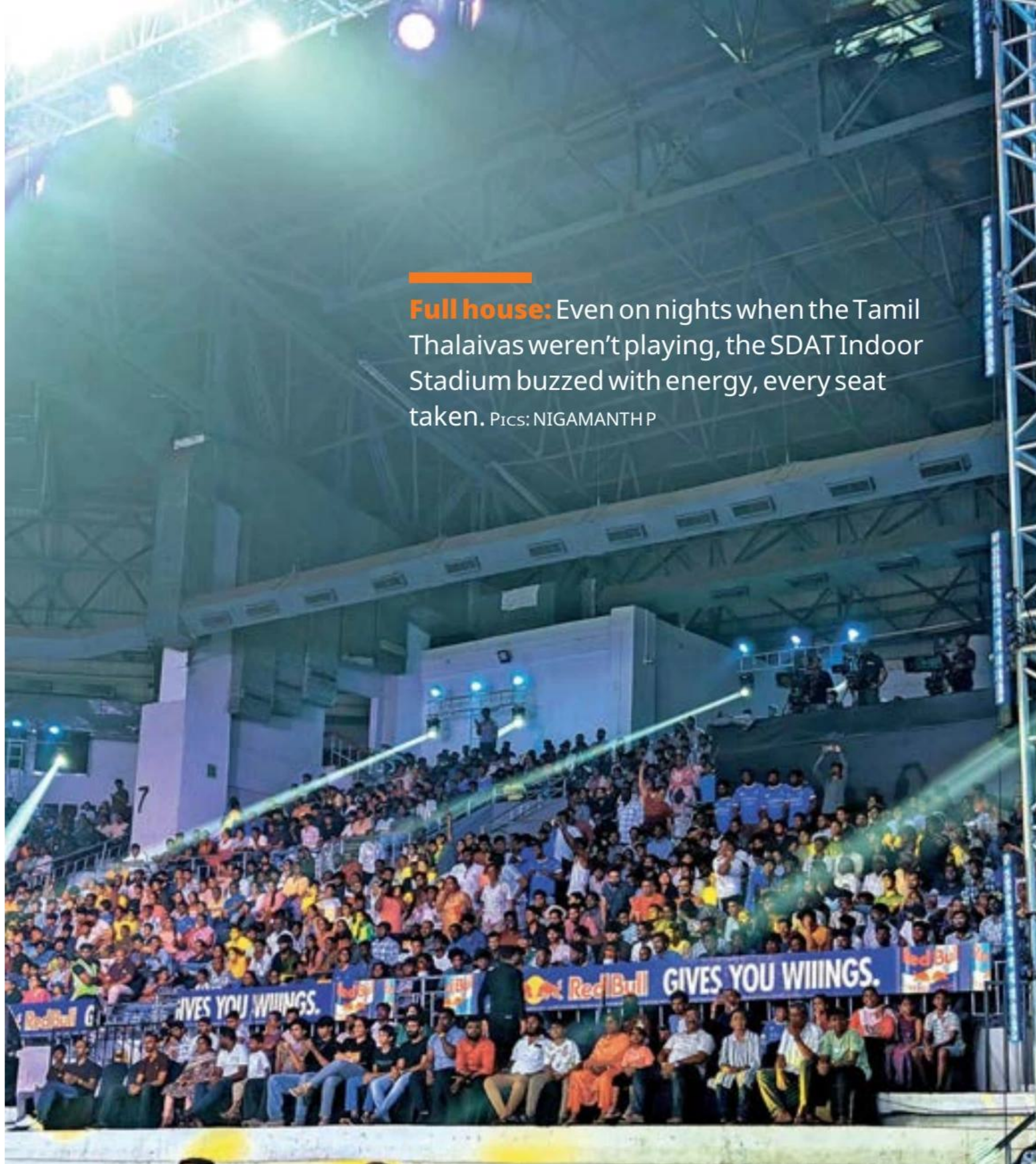




Full house: Even on nights when the Tamil Thalaivas weren't playing, the SDAT Indoor Stadium buzzed with energy, every seat taken. PICS: NIGAMANTH P

immediately visible, hidden behind a ring of blazing LED hoardings. What greets the eye instead is the sheer verticality of the lighting structure: rows of lamps aimed across the arena — most facing the mat, some trained on the crowd — all dazzlingly bright. For this reporter, kabaddi existed primarily as a television spectacle. But watching it live, however, revealed an entirely different theatre.

That sense of theatre begins the moment one walks in. The speakers pulse with up-tempo tracks, more Tamil songs on Thalaivas matchdays, to rouse the crowd. Once play begins, the music gives way to the sharp countdown of the raid clock or the echoing chant of "Do or Die," blaring from a line-array above, pressing down on the audience like atmospheric weight.

The lights play their part too. Each match opens with the captains' handshake — a brief truce highlighted by spotlights. Do-or-Die raids trigger flashing graphics across the LED panels, a reminder of the

stakes. Together, the lighting and sound systems shape the entire experience, ensuring no one in the arena loses the thread: an essential element for a sport still expanding its audience.

It's easy to romanticise sport as something so gripping it needs no embellishment, that true competition speaks for itself. Perhaps that still holds at times. But if sport is theatre, then great athletes are its actors and it is the craft of lights, sound, and set design that transforms a good play into a memorable one.

The actors of PKL are of the highest calibre. Night after night, their athleticism, strength, and nerve produce gripping drama. Reflecting on that spectacle, it feels only right to acknowledge the unseen professionals — the sound and light engineers — who elevate high-quality sport into a fully immersive experience, both for those in the arena and those watching from afar.

Aditya Padinjat

